



This watch tells time...

... and gives *weather alerts*, and *news updates*, and pings *appointment alerts*, and sends you *instant messages*, and *manages your schedules*. Soon, it may tell you *which girlfriend to date* this evening. Want to know how it works?

It's not quite James Bond's watch. Yet. Agent 007's legendary Omega has laser beam metal cutters built into it, a two-way videophone and remote detonators for mines scattered about the country. However, one glance at the newest range of Fossil Wrist Netwatches, and you are convinced that they're a fantasy come true.

Put Microsoft's Smart Personal Objects Technology (SPOT) on your wrist and you get news and weather updates, stock quotes, sports scores, instant messages via MSN Messenger as well as alarms that work in coordination with Outlook. Of course, you can also use it to tell time with precision, since it's set using an atomic clock as reference.

Microsoft's SPOT initiative aims to see more intelligent daily objects providing useable information at a glance. The idea is to take something as ordinary as a watch, a keychain, or a refrigerator magnet, look at what its primary role is and see how this can be enhanced.

A little over a year later, that's what they have done with the first of their SPOT hardware, taking watches, and developing them into an entirely new computing platform. Microsoft worked with chip manufacturer, National Semiconductors, and communication experts, SCA Data Systems, to design the platform and the networking protocol that drives it.

Now, Microsoft has partnered with sports watch manufacturers, Fossil and Suunto, who use this new platform in their smart watches to provide customers in 100 locations in North America with content from Microsoft's MSN Direct service.

SPOT isn't going to be limited to watches. More intelligent everyday devices are on their way, but the watch is prime real estate to start from. Think fantasy devices, and watches are a part of the deal.